Xinyi Liu

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Education

Northwestern University — Evanston, IL
Ph.D. in Media, Technology, and Society — 2024–2029 (Expected)
Advisor: Dr. Yingdan Lu

Nanyang Technological University — Singapore
M.A. in Communication — 2022–2024
Advisor: Dr. Shirley S. Ho

Communication University of China — Beijing, China
B.A. in French Literature (minor in Digital Media and Art) — 2018–2022

Publications

Peer-reviewed Journal Articles

[4] **Liu, X.**, Peng, Y., & Lu, Y. Mitigating Confounder Bias in Observational Studies of Visual Media Effects. (Conditional Acceptance, *Human Communication Research*)

[3] Lu, Y., **Liu, X.**, & Zhou, C. (2026). Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State-Created Content in China. *Journal of Communication*, jqag010. https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqag010

[2] **Liu, X.**, Lu, Y., Peng, Q., Qian, S., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026) Seeing the Surreal: Mapping Surrealism in Photorealistic AI-Generated Images Using Large Language Models. *Computational Communication Research, 8*(2), 1. https://doi.org/10.5117/CCR2026.2.6.LIU

[1] Peng, Q., Lu, Y., Peng, Y., Qian, S., **Liu, X.**, & Shen, C. (2025). Crafting Synthetic Realities: Examining Visual Realism and Misinformation Potential of Photorealistic AI-Generated Images. *Proceedings of the Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, CHI EA '25, 1–12. https://doi.org/10.1145/3706599.3719834

Book Chapter

[1] **Liu, X.**, Lin, C., & Lu, Y. Computational Visual Analysis in Communication Research: A Critical Examination of Methods, Challenges, and Opportunities. (Forthcoming in *Critical Visual Research Methods for Social Media*).

Conference Presentations

[12] **Liu, X.**, Peng, Y., & Lu, Y. Mitigating Confounder Bias in Observational Studies of Visual Media Effects. (2026, July). *2026 Annual Meeting of the Society for Political Methodology, Lansing, USA*, [poster presentation]

[11] **Liu, X.**, Peng, Y., & Lu, Y. Mitigating Confounder Bias in Observational Studies of Visual Media Effects. (2026, July). *12th International Conference on Computational Social Science, Burlington, USA*, [poster presentation]

[10] **Liu, X.**, Lu, Y., Peng, Q., Qian, S., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, July). Seeing the Surreal: Mapping Surrealism in Photorealistic AI-Generated Images Using Large Language Models. *12th International Conference on Computational Social Science, Burlington, USA*

[9] Lu, Y., **Liu, X.**, & Zhou, C. (2026, June). Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State Content in China. Scheduled at *76th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Cape Town, South Africa.*

[8] **Liu, X.**, Lu, Y., Peng, Q., Qian, S., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, June). Seeing the Surreal: Mapping Surrealism in Photorealistic AI-Generated Images Using Large Language Models. *76th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Cape Town, South Africa.*

[7] **Liu, X.**, Lu, Y., Peng, Q., Qian, S., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, May). Seeing the Surreal: Mapping Surrealism in Photorealistic AI-Generated Images Using Large Language Models. *Comm Horizons @UCD 2026, Sacramento, USA.*

[6] Lu, Y., **Liu, X.**, & Zhou, C. (2025, September). Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State Content in China. Presented at *2025 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Vancouver, Canada.*

[5] Lu, Y., **Liu, X.**, & Zhou, C. (2025, July). Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State Content in China. Presented at *18th Annual Political Networks and Computational Social Science Conference (PolNet-PaCSS), Boston, USA*, [poster presentation]

[4] Lu, Y., **Liu, X.**, & Zhou, C. (2025, July). Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State Content in China. Presented at *11th International Conference on Computational Social Science, Norrköping, Sweden.*

[Best Lightning Talk Award]

[3] **Liu, X.**, & Ho, S. S. (2024, June). Human, AI, vs. synergy agency: How agency framing affects perceived uncertainty, controllability, and trust in AI in autonomous vehicles. *74th Annual International Communication Association (ICA) Conference*

[2] **Liu, X.**, Xiao, Q., Liang, D., & Pan, Y. (2023, Aug). Agency and modality interaction: Exploring the impact of multimodal AI-generated content on news credibility. *2023 Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC) Annual Conference*

[1] **Liu, X.**, Liang, D., Tong-Laurence, G., Lin, S., & Kang, H. (2023, May). A false sense of reality: Effects of augmented reality (AR) filters on communication willingness. *73rd Annual International Communication Association (ICA) Conference*

Awards and Grants

2025 OpenAI Researcher Access Program, $1,000 worth API credits

2025 Best Lightning Talk Award, 11th International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2)

2020 Excellent Student Journalist of Communication University of China

2020 Youth Leadership Project Grant (7,000 RMB), United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) & National Health and Family Planning Commission (NHFPC)

Teaching and Research Supervisor

Teaching Assistant

COMM_ST 272: Creativity and the Business of Entertainment 2026
Teaching Assistant and Guest Lecture

COMM_ST 101-1: Communication in Context: Introduction 2026
Teaching Assistant and Guest Lecture

COMM_ST 379 / POLI_SCI 390: Digital Propaganda and Repression 2025
Teaching Assistant and Guest Lecture

Academic Services

Association-related Service:

Panel chair - IC2S2 2026, "Understanding Large Language Models (AI & Society)"

Reviewer

Peer-reviewed Journals:

- Science Advances

Lab-related Service

Lab Manager, Computational Media and Politics (COMAP) Lab (PI: Yingdan Lu) 2024 –
Lab Manager, Computational Multi-Modal Communication (CMMC) Lab 2024 –
(PI: Yingdan Lu, Yilang Peng, Cuihua (Cindy) Shen)

Others

Student volunteer - 2026 Lambert ANN SONIC NICO Workshop "Reimagining Human-Centered Computing Research in the Age of AI"
Student volunteer - ICA 2024 Pre-Conference "The Future of Computational Message Science: Theoretical Advances, Computational Frontiers, and Grand Societal Challenges"

Research Experience

Northwestern University Evanston, IL
Graduate Research Assistant, Global LLM Values Benchmarking Working Group 2025 –
(Funded by Northwestern Buffett Institute for Global Affairs)

Nanyang Technological University Singapore
Graduate Research Assistant (PI: Shirley S. Ho) 2022–2024

Skills

Language: English (Fluent), French (B2), Mandarin (Native)

Programming: R, Python, SPSS, ATLAS.ti, LaTeX

Other Software: Adobe Creative Suite, Final Cut Pro